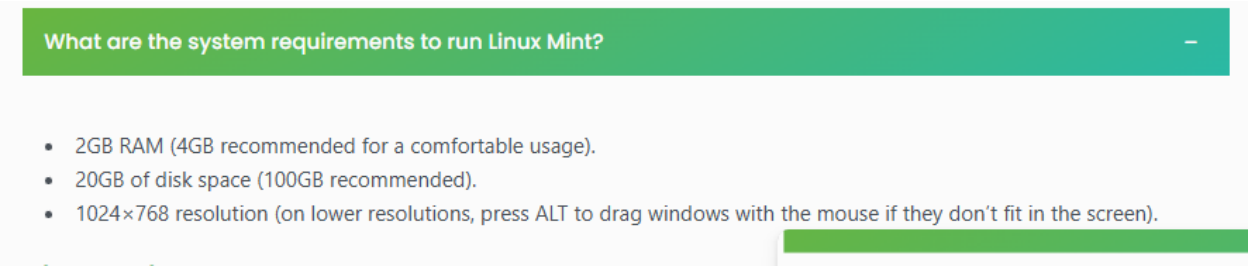
Linux Mint (Cinnamon edition)

I went to https://linuxmint.com/download.php for the iso download. I would like to note that it was the simplest and easy to find and download out of the three.



I found the system requirements on the webpage and followed that roughly as a guide for my virtual box settings.

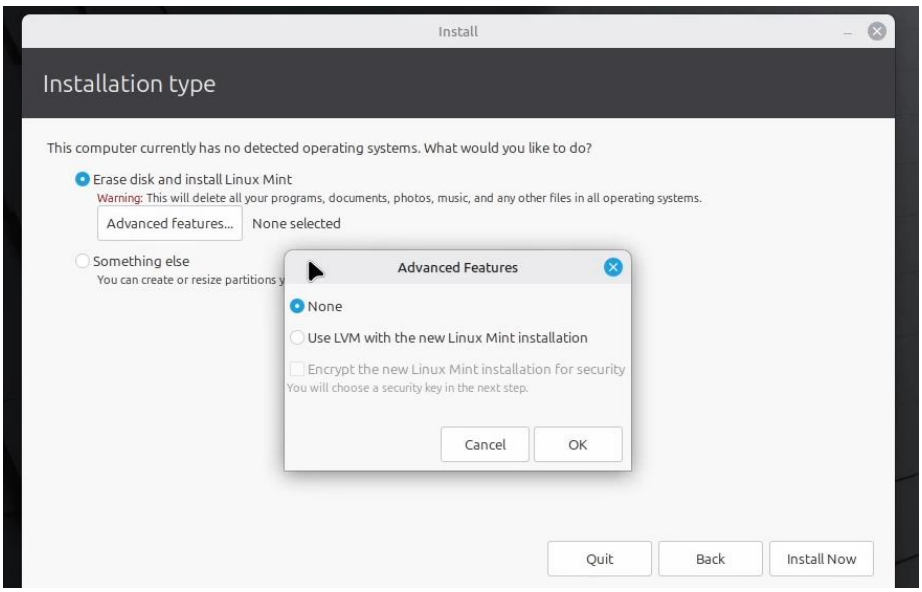
I chose 4gb of ram, 2 CPU cores, 50gb for the disk size and 128mb for video memory.

Linux Mint uses ext4 by default for its file system by default.

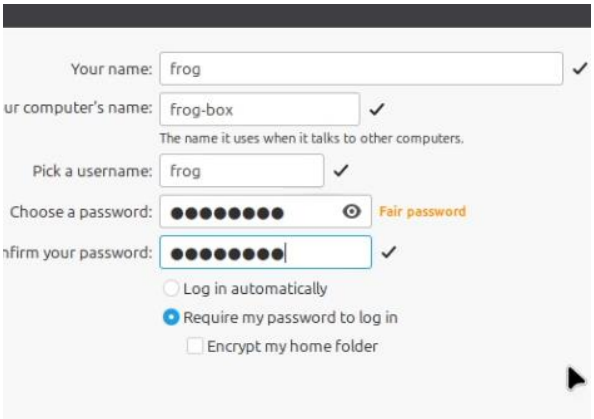
I loaded up linux mint and started the installation. One thing I noted is in my experience with installing Linux distros they were not live installs, so I was a little thrown off by the live environment. I found and referenced this simple and quick video on YouTube with a little help from ChatGPT to clarify questions I had.

https://youtu.be/ulQWy5o-tps?si=w3zuv1eIh17Iij4T

During installation I kept it encryption free. I figured Mint was the simplest and most user friendly, so maybe the average user wouldn't be using encryption.



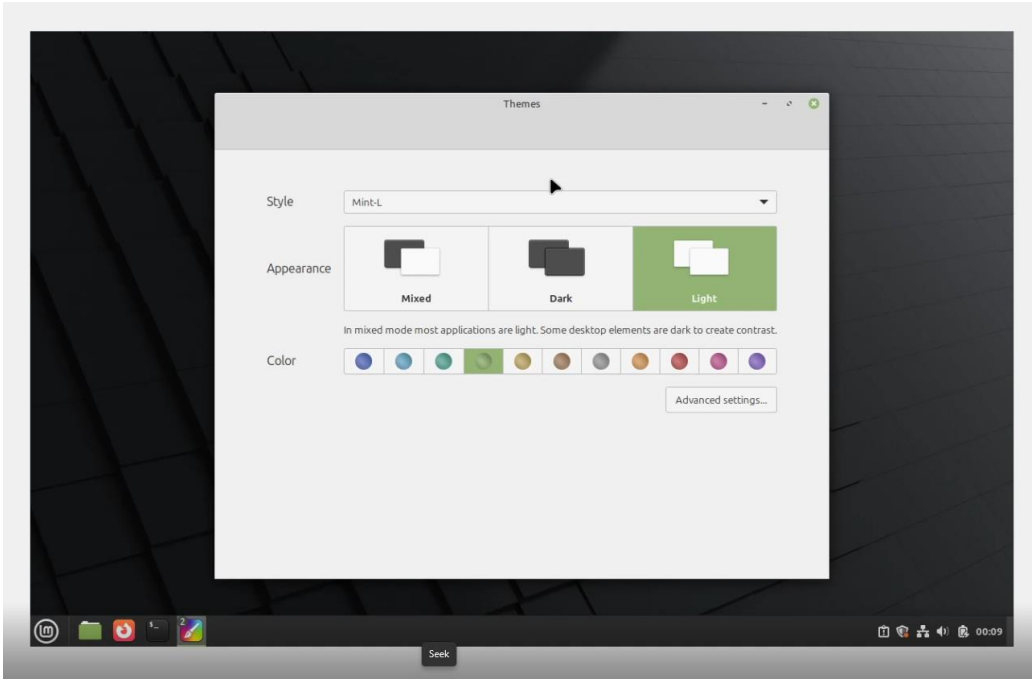
After this i set the computer name, username and set a password.



One thing i noted is settings for swap were not presented on setup. I looked into it and found you could change it but swap is configured automatically by the installer on mint.

https://www.reddit.com/r/linux4noobs/comments/1infgb3/how_to_formatcreate_swap_partition_for_linux_mint/

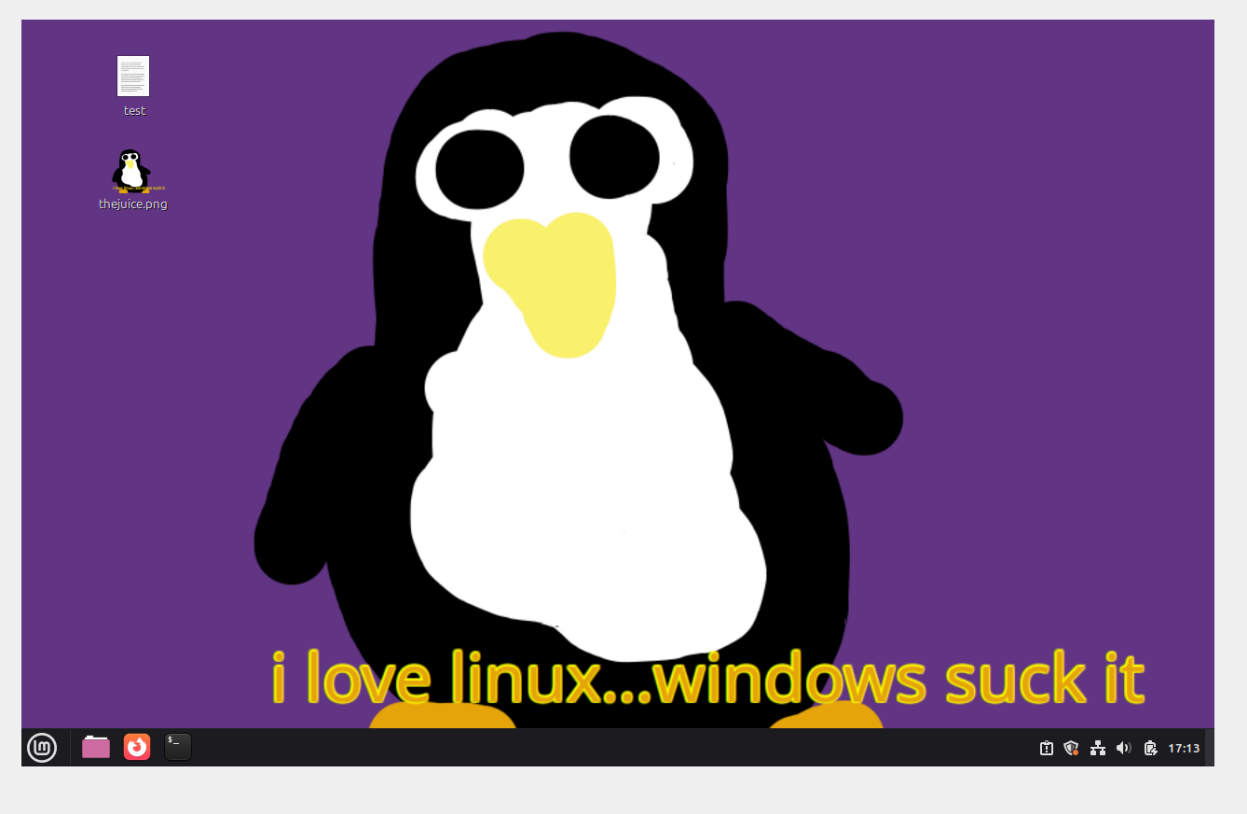
When install and setup was complete, it loaded in a welcome GUI. It gave options to scroll through i found some customization options for theme and colors. Overall, the layout of the desktop and the windows were sleek and simple. It reminded me of using mac iOS back in middle school on school computers.



After browsing the settings and options on the welcome screen I got to work checking out the menu and available tools.

Libre office was installed which is a decent office toolset.

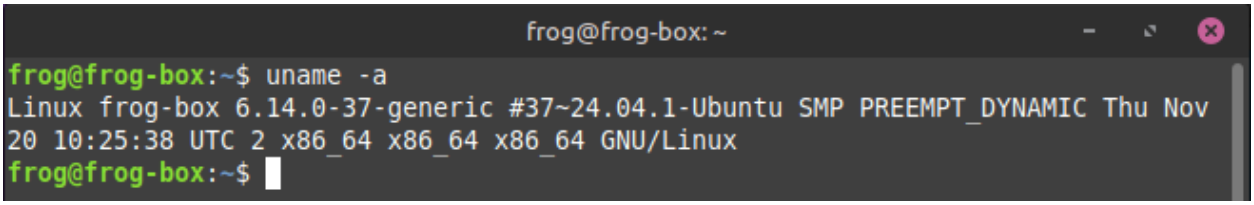
I found a paint program and made a sweet custom wallpaper. To change the wallpaper was a simple right click on the desktop.



I opened Firefox and loaded up YouTube and played a video. Sound worked with no issue.

I found the software manager which was like a little app store. In there I found freetube an opensource add free version of YouTube. I downloaded that and gave it a run.

I hit the terminal and gave it the ole “sudo apt update” and “sudo apt upgrade” And then ran “uname –a”



Overall, I thought the process of installing and running was simple. It has a sleek design i even found it to do some tiling with the windows by default. I would feel comfortable using mint in the future as a daily driver comparable or better than windows.

Fedora (Workstation – Gnome)

Downloaded the iso from the official website: https://www.fedoraproject.org/

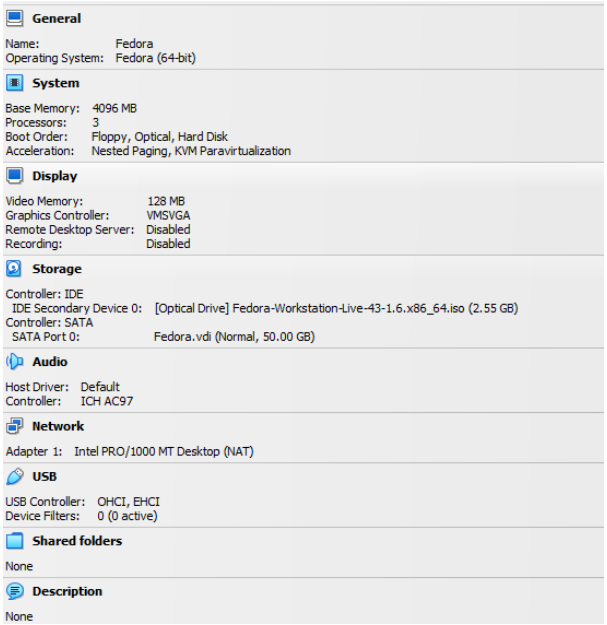
I also located system requirements on their website

System Requirements

To have a good experience, hardware with a 40GB SSD disk and 4GB RAM is recommended for Fedora Workstation. However, it is possible to use hardware with lower specifications.

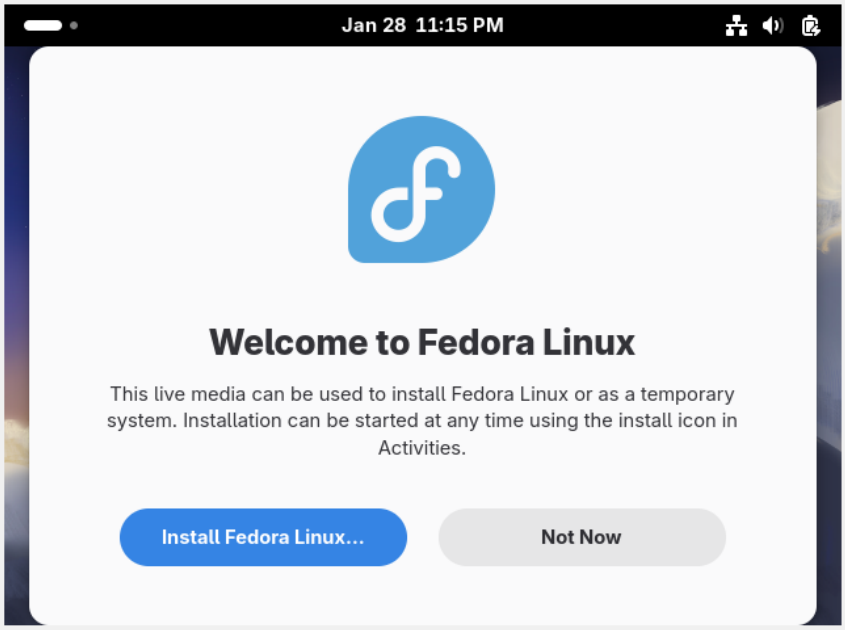
Workstation images are available for x86_64 and aarch64 architectures, providing support for Intel, AMD and ARM processors.

I choose 4gb of ram, 2 CPU cores, 50gb for the disk size and 128mb for video memory.

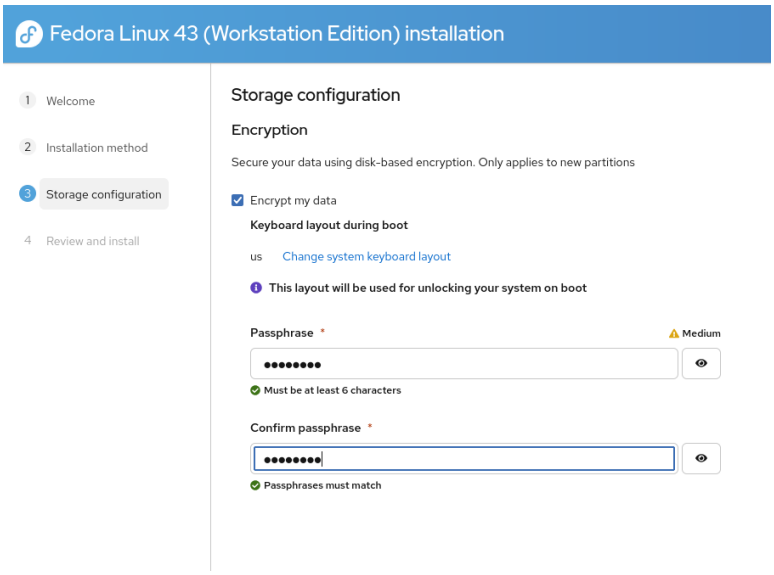


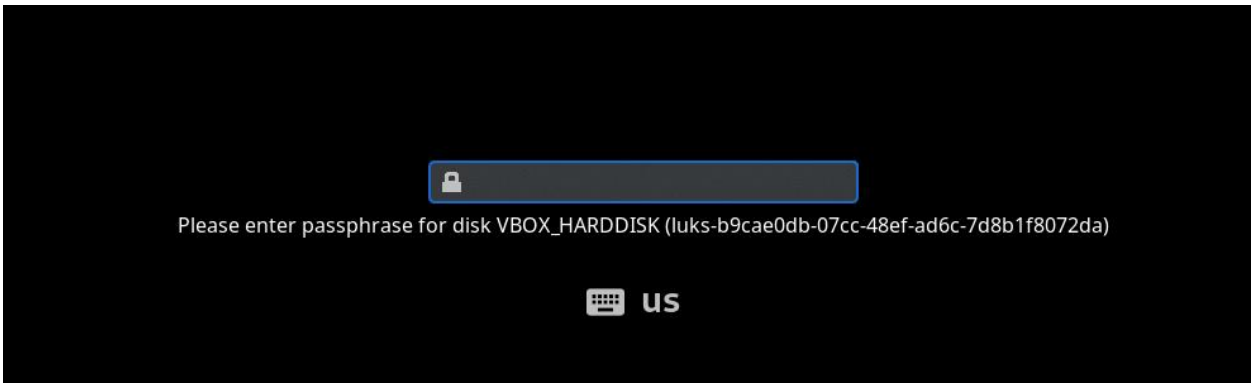
I used this youtube video as a simple guide
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WVvH5ppWApU

I fired up fedora and was greeted with an install screen and it had an explanation of the fact that it was live media and would need an install...mint left me high and dry on that one.

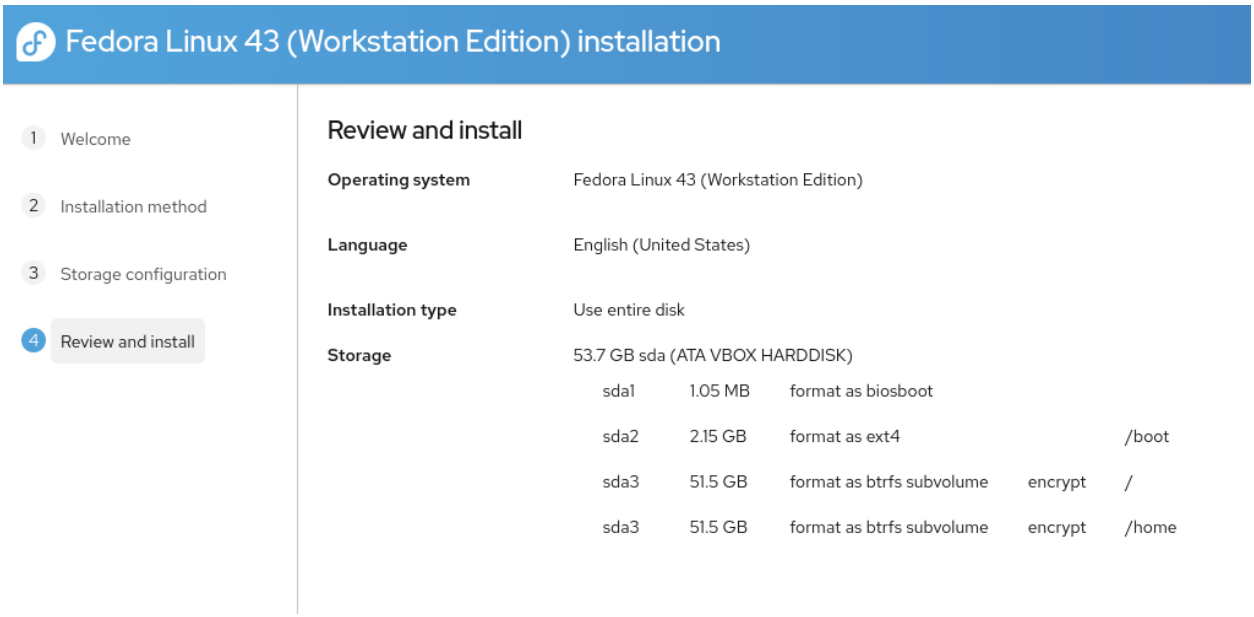


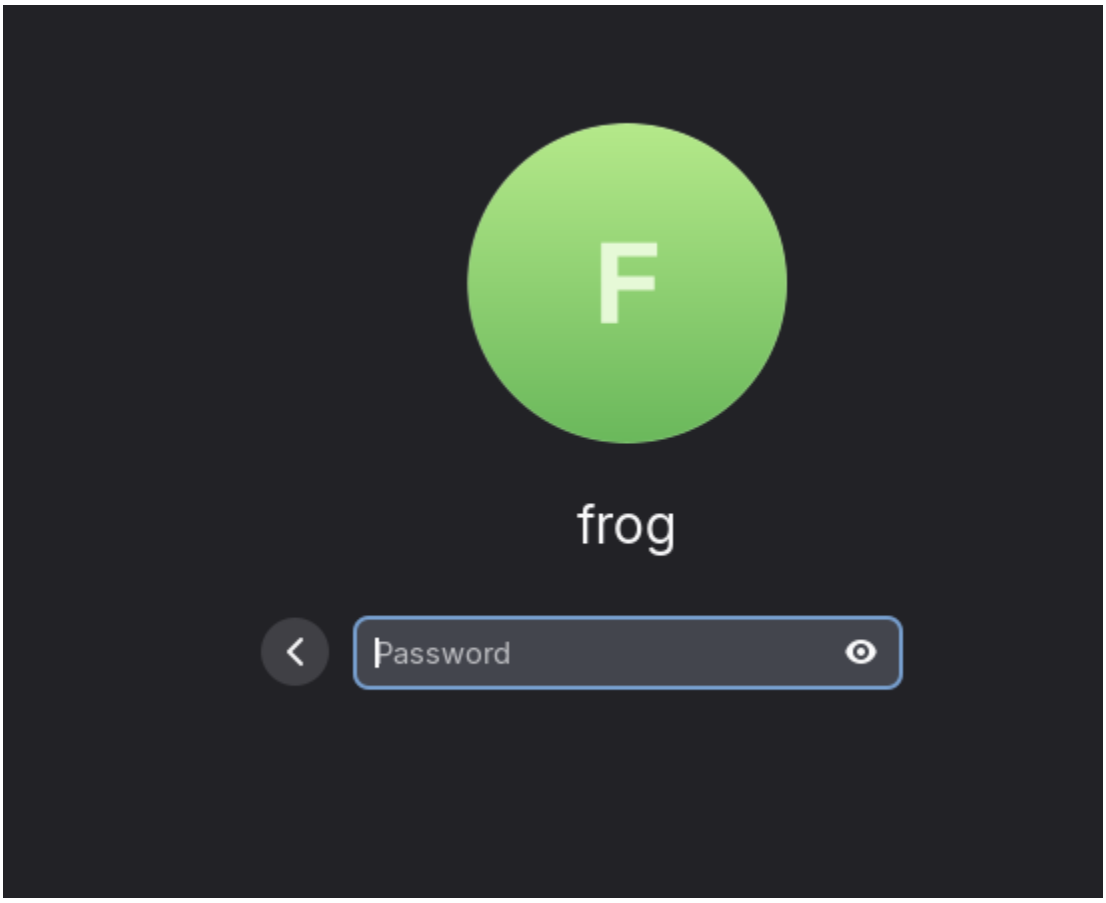
I followed the prompts and selected to encrypt my data. I double checked and fedora uses LUKS encryption.




Please enter passphrase for disk VBOX_HARDDISK (luks-b9cae0db-07cc-48ef-ad6c-7d8b1f8072da)
us

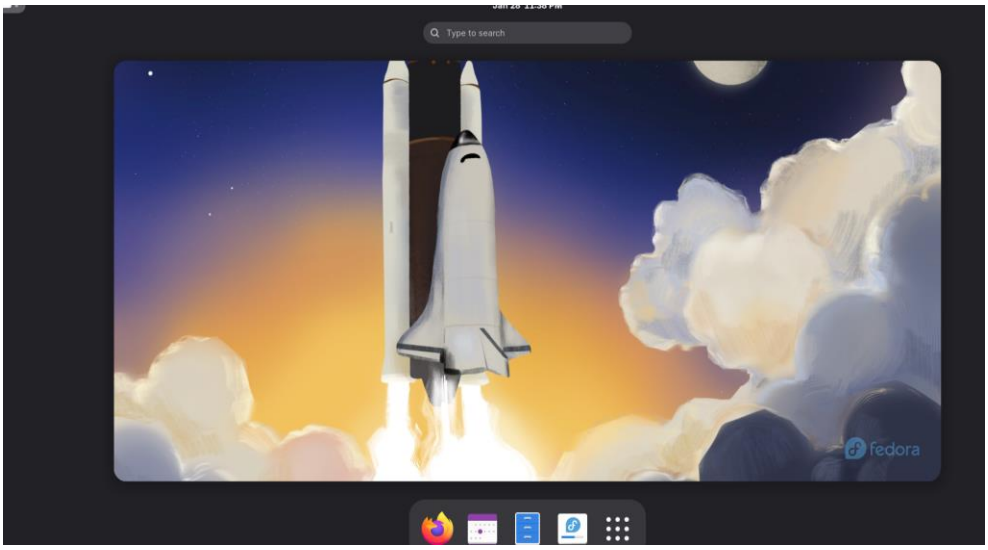
I also noted on the review and install page that the file system was formatted as Btrfs.



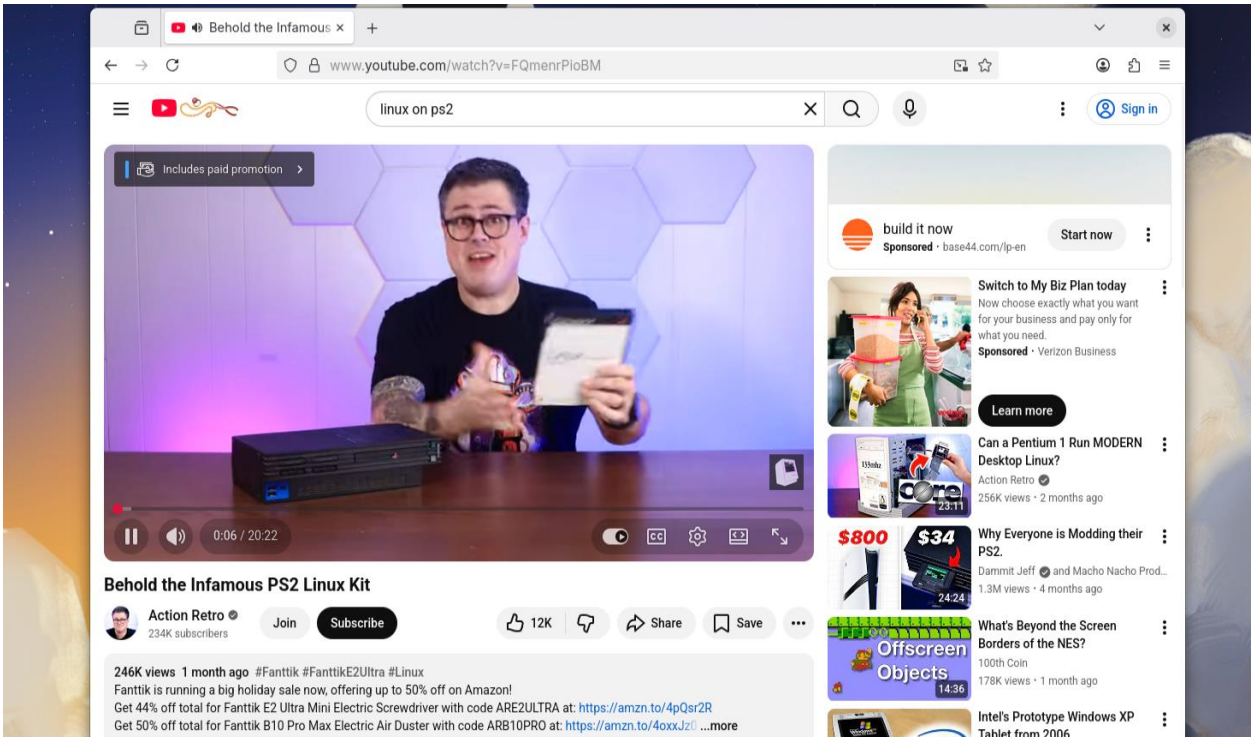


after install i had to remove the iso file from vm to get it to load into the installed version.

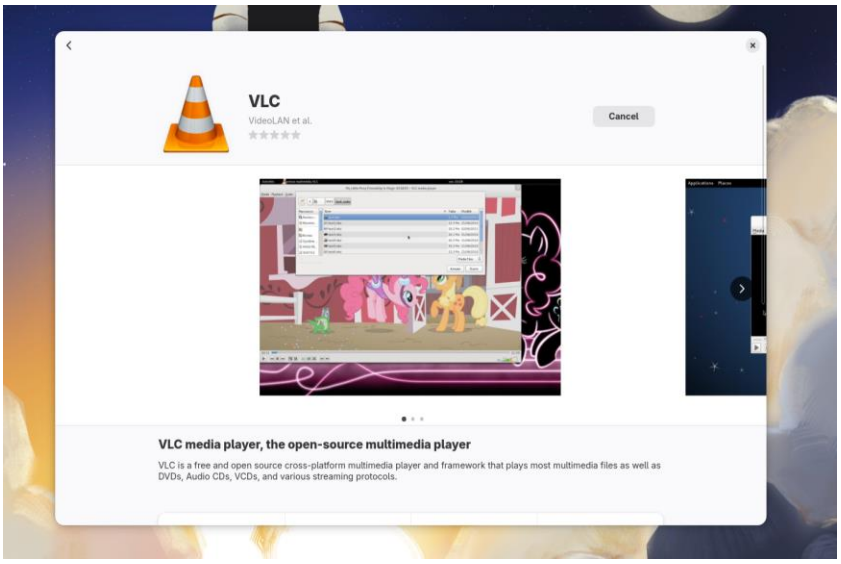
I loaded in to the desktop after install and at first thought there was something wrong with my screen formatting and that I was missing a task bar. At the top right there is a icon to press that opens up a sort of dashboard setup. You can navigate to another workstation which i really like just by clicking on it on the right of the dashboard. I have never used a desktop setup like this and after zooming around it for a few minutes i found it smooth and fun to use.



I started the daily driving. Firefox was installed so i hopped on youtube and watched some of a video about linux for ps2.



I swung over and checked out the file explorer. With a saw it had a video player but i found the store and located VLC to cover audio and video. Fedora also came with libre office. I like that its been installed by default on both linux distros ive tried. I don't mind using the Microsoft suite because its provided with my schooling but I would never pay to use it. Libre can also save as docx so I think that's cool!



I hopped into the terminal and pinned it to the dash to make it easier to get to. I ran “sudo apt update" and was quickly reminded that fedora doesn't use apt... this is also when I learned that when you run “sudo dnf update” it does what update and upgrade does using apt. That was kind of wild.

```
frog@fedora:~$ uname -a
Linux fedora 6.17.1-300.fc43.x86_64 #1 SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Mon Oct  6 15:37:21 UTC 2025 x86_64 GNU/Linux
frog@fedora:~$
```

I enjoyed fedora. It felt like a cooler looking version of mint. Things loaded faster then on mint. I'm not sure if my pc was just in a better mood or if I'm crazy but it genuinely felt like a faster experience. I did think it was weird that there wasn't a button on the desktop at the top to open terminal or that if i saved something to the desktop it didn't show up and you had to use the file explorer to find it on the desktop. This does keep things minimal and is an obvious design choice. I don't love or hate it and the more I used it the more I enjoyed it. After a little google search I found I could customize both things to the way I wanted if I felt the need to change it later on.

openSUSE (Tumbleweed - Plasma 5)

Download the iso from the official website: https://get.opensuse.org/tumbleweed/

I also located the minimum system requirements on the same site

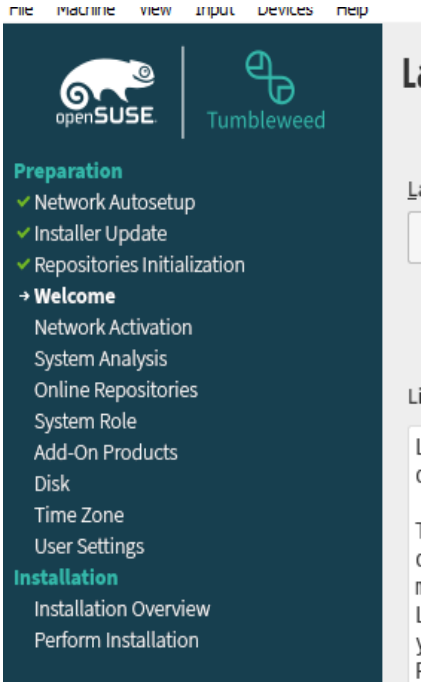
Minimum system requirements

- Any AMD64/Intel* EM64T processor (32-bit processors are not supported).
- 1 GB physical RAM (4 GB or more strongly recommended).
- 10 GB available disk space for a minimal installation, 16 GB for a graphical desktop (more is recommended). In case you plan to use *Btrfs* snapshots, a minimum of 40 GB for the root partition is recommended.
- Supports most modern sound and graphics cards, 1024 x 768 display resolution (higher recommended).

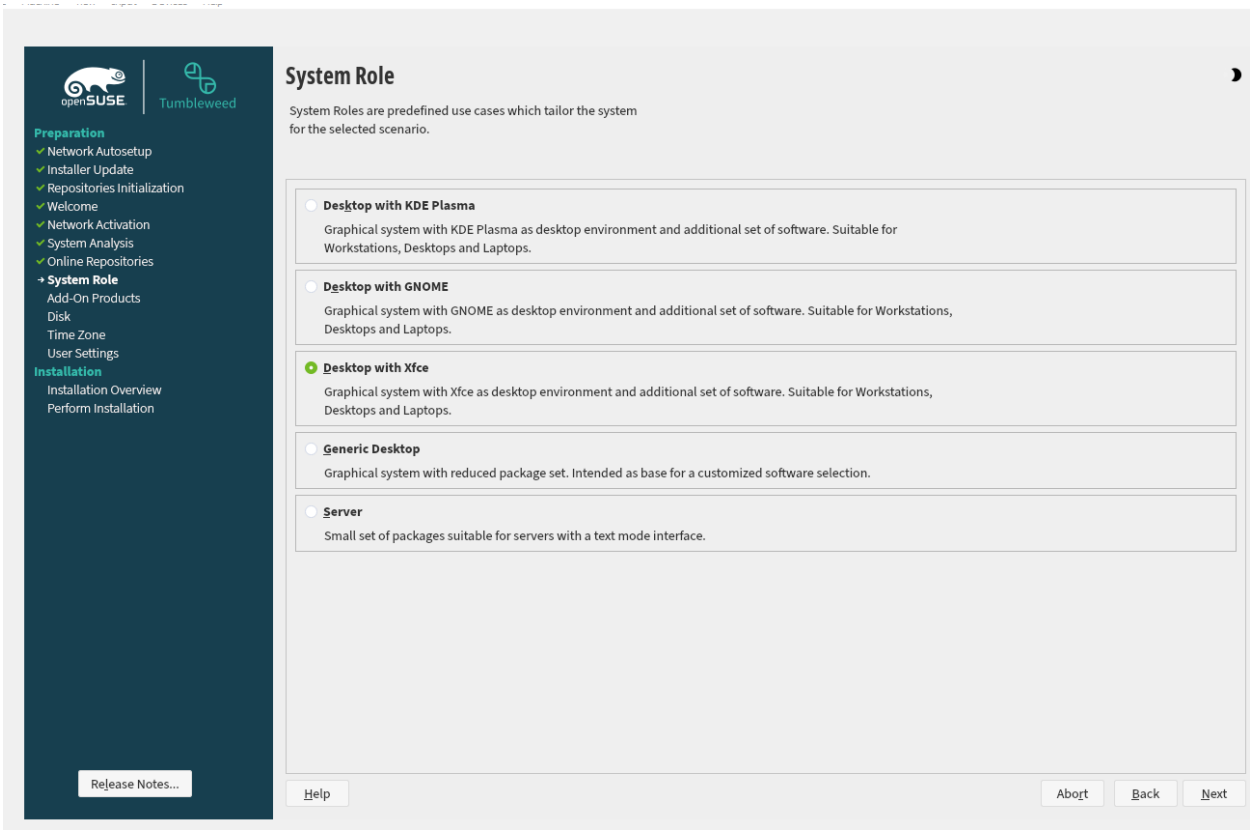
I prepped a YouTube video in a tab for easy walkthrough:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zmEAtN7WorE

I choose 4gb of ram, 2 CPU cores, 50gb for the disk size and 128mb for video memory. (this has just been my go to for most box's I use and unless it calls for more I tend to keep these settings)

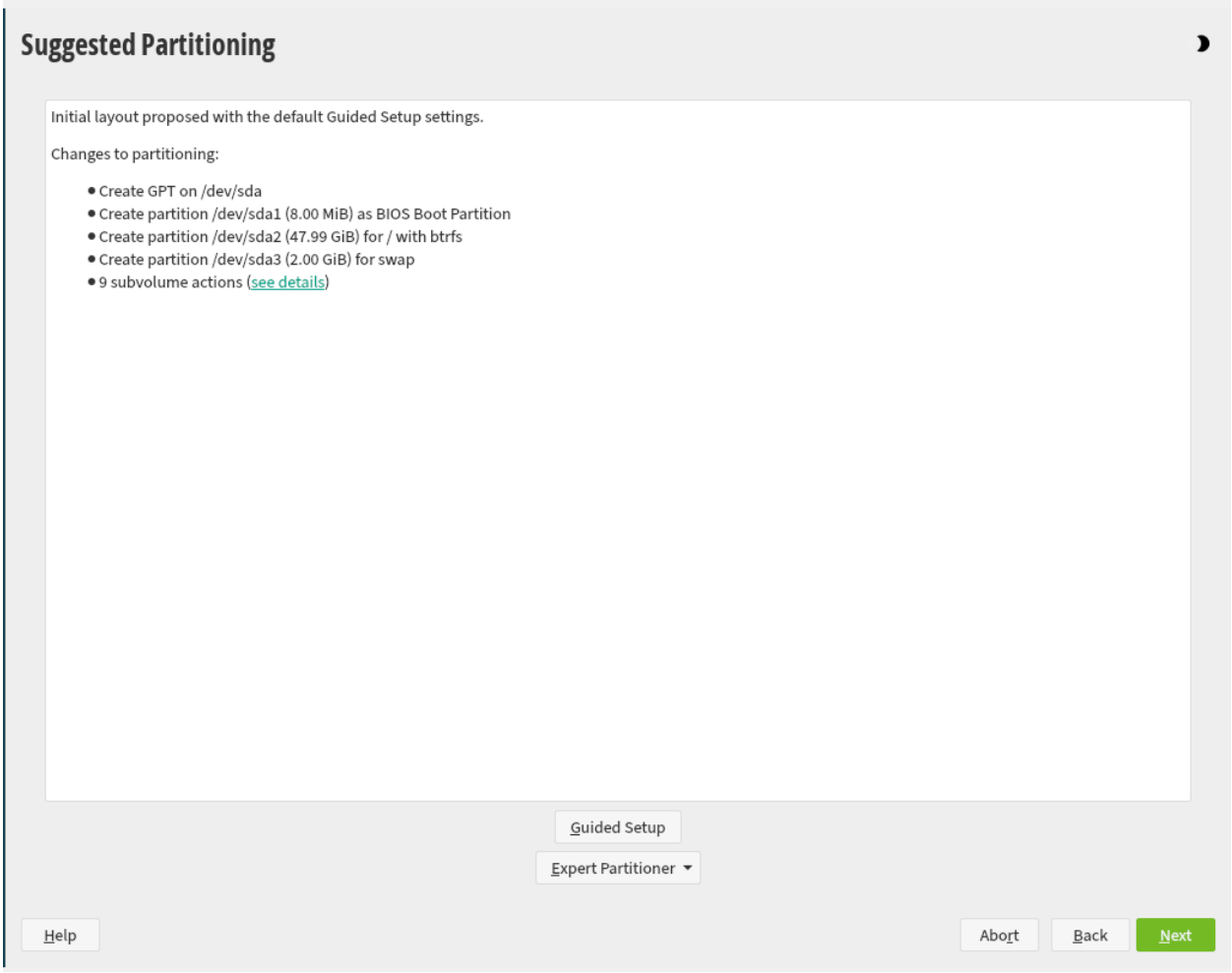
After starting the vm you have the option to boot straight into the installation. Right out the gate I can see there's a ALOT more options for setting up openSUSE



Some things i wanted to highlight would be the ability to change the file system, choose encryption and set a swap. This is and a bunch more is all available and in the open right from the beginning unlike fedora or mint. I like this as someone who is more technically inclined...but i could see this being a barrier to a beginner or someone who isn't afraid of the possibility of a challenge.

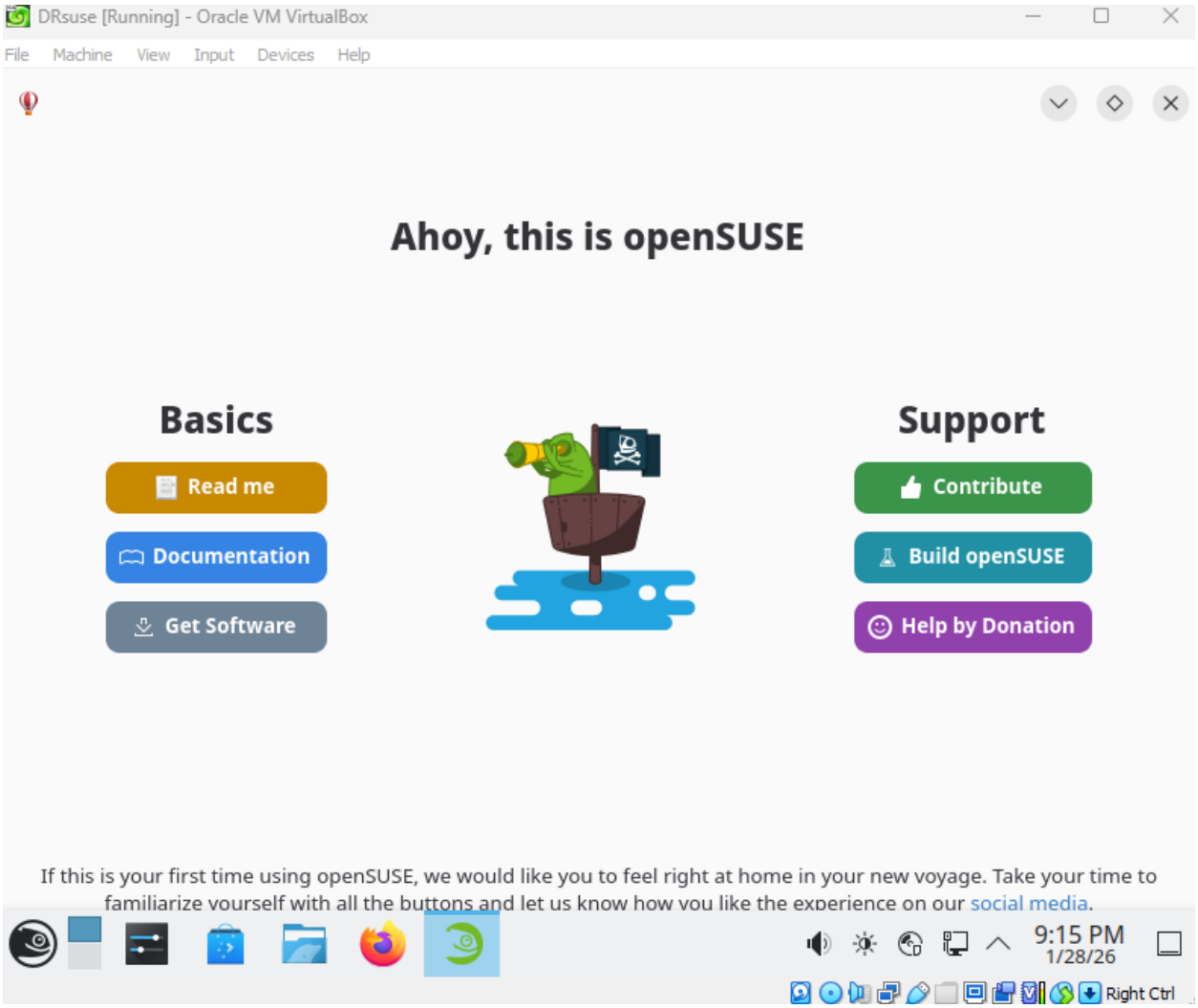


I selected KDE plasma desktop environment. Fedora used the gnome environment so we have seen that already and as far as i understand mint uses its own desktop environment.

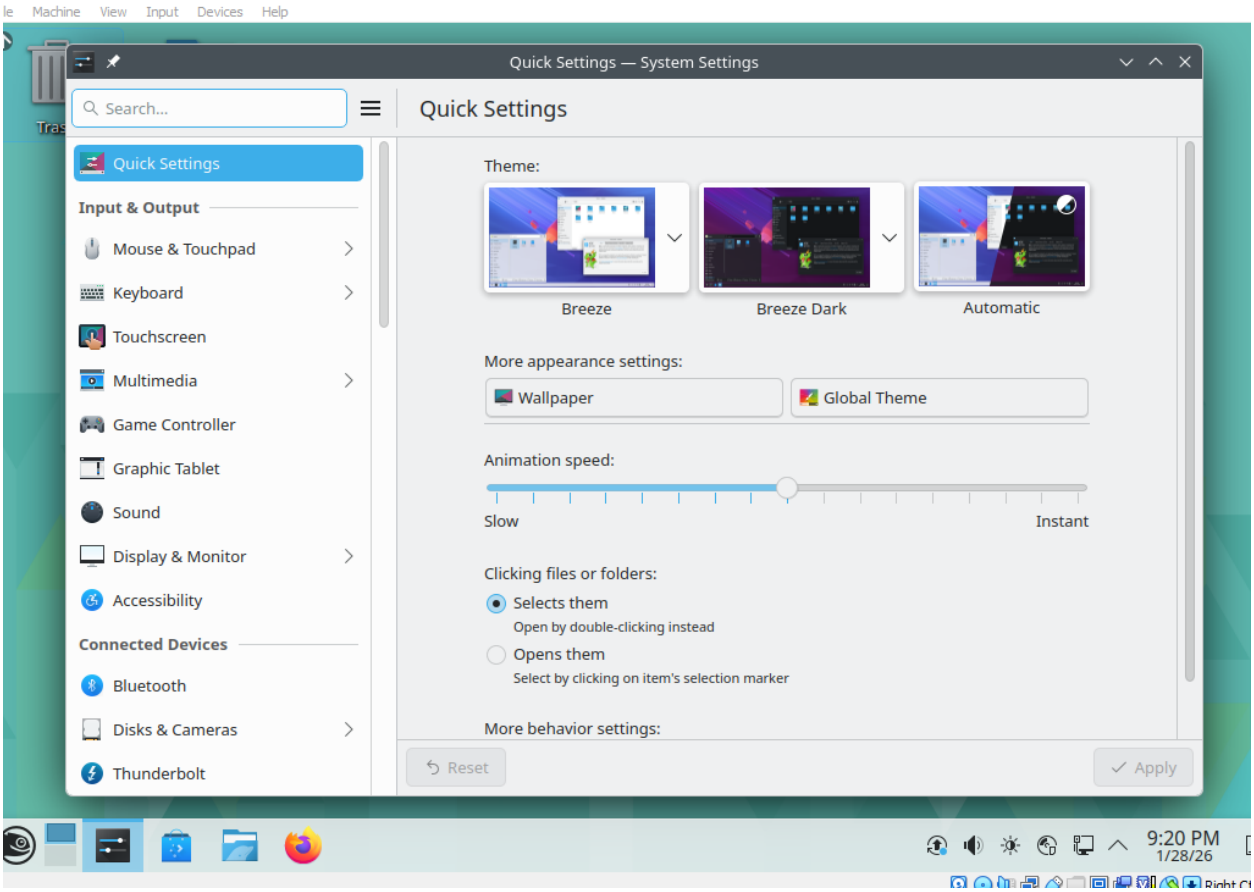


It shows a suggested partition screen. This is the first of the three that offered this. You can click the expert partitioner button to adjust partitions and change the filesystem type as well. I opted to keep these settings.

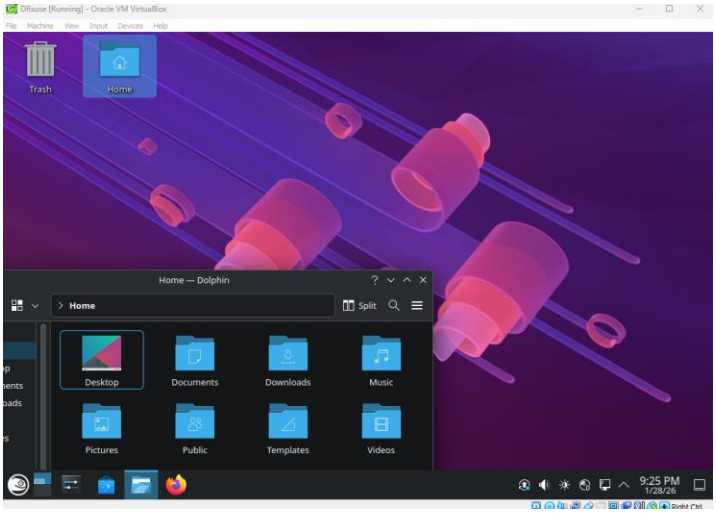
After a very long time...hahaha we are in!



Im already a fan of the chameleon pirate. It opens with a readme and documentation right out in the open which is awesome! After exiting out of this a help center also pops up with more info....it prompts you to update and was already showing me what needed to be updated. The desktop and toolbar has a more familiar windows feel that I'm used to. When I clicked on the settings shortcut instead of a loading wheel it had the emblem of the thing I was opening bouncing up and down below my mouse. That was kind of cool.



Settings where right on the task bar. I was able to do some quick and simple customizing. I hit it with some dark theme and a cool wallpaper.



For daily driving we got the good ole firfox again. I have had enough with Firefox...i went to the software store and downloaded Zen browser and loaded up a YouTube video. I like it. Zen is nice.

It has libre office once again which I would never complain about. VLC player came installed for audio and video. I went to the terminal and noticed my hostname was not set so I googled that and found “sudo hostnamectl set-hostname NEWNAME” and set my hostname to pepe after the beloved frog. I also noticed openSUSE has a really nice screen shot feature when I was taking this screen shot. Lots of options and features compared to fedora and mint.

```
drsuse@pepe:~> uname -a
Linux pepe 6.18.7-1-default #1 SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Fri Jan 23 12:13:24 UTC 2026 (14faf12) x86_64 x86_64 x86_64
 GNU/Linux
drsuse@pepe:~>
```

OpenSUSE was a great experience, I enjoyed how “hands on” it felt compared to the others. I'm not super huge into the graphical customization and I have been a windows user my whole life so the desktop environment and the way it looks and feels. For what it's worth I have a decent following on a certain Chinese spyware app and I have been posting videos asking about linux and ALOT of people that don't say arch say they use openSUSE. So, I think that's cool!

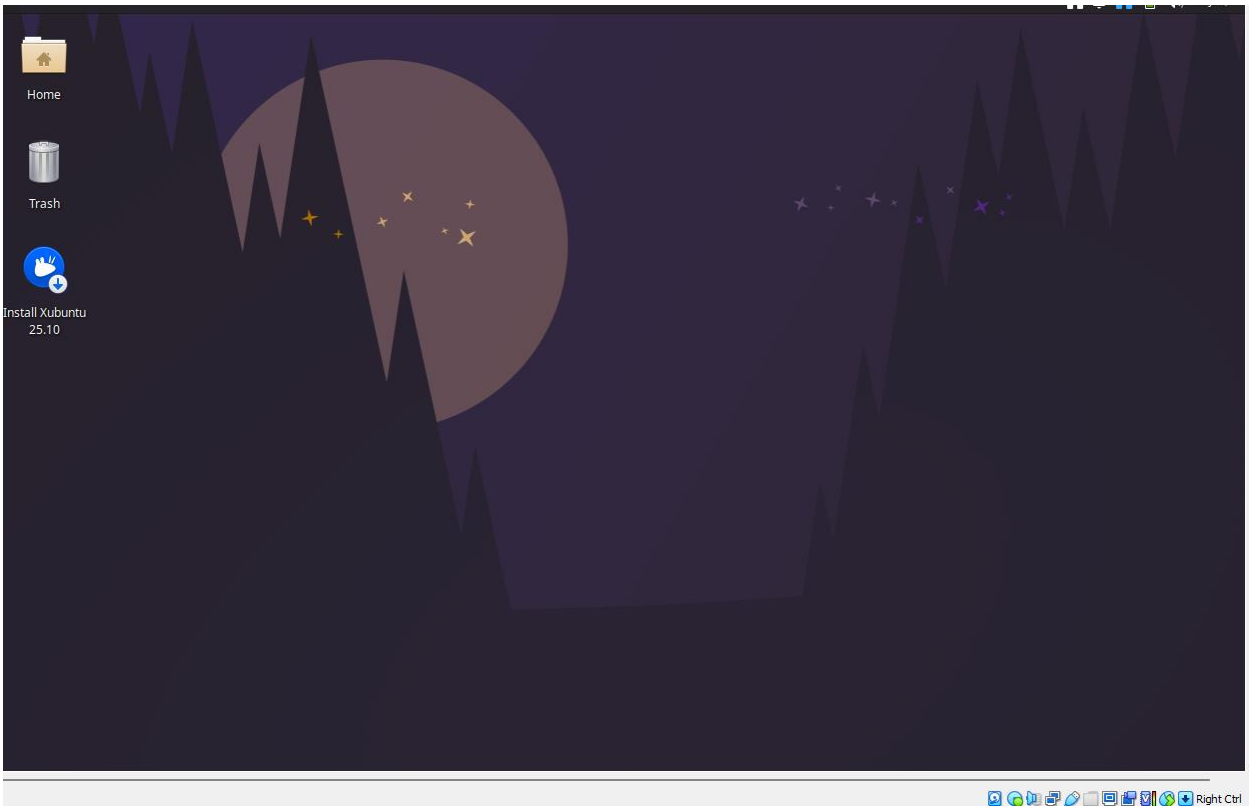
For my choice in distro i went with Xubuntu. It's a community developed version of Ubuntu. I chose it because it was on the front page of distrowatch when I loaded up the website and it had the tag “elegant and easy to use operating system". I'm interested to see if its just kind of like mint or if it's actually elegant. Lets dive iiiiiiiiiiiiin!

https://xubuntu.org/

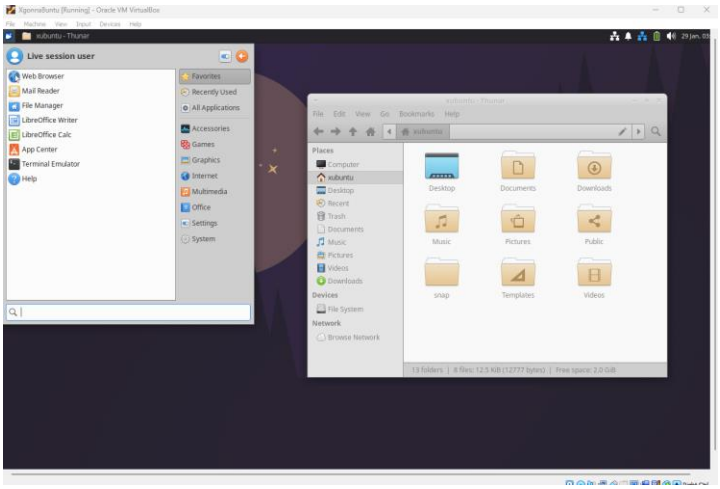
For the first time i got a 404error on the link to the system requirements, I'm feeling lazy and I'm going to use the same settings I have been using...if this curses me...I blame the elegance...it had me dazed. I did how ever find a YouTube video for setup. It was the most recent uploaded out of any of the distro videos I could find so i enjoy that the community is actively uploading content. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bD6MxarwtZE (classic IT guy from India as well A+ content) some things to note is that Xubuntu uses XFCE for its desktop environment. This is a new desktop environment for us to try! By default it uses ext4 as its filesystem.

I choose 4gb of ram, 2 CPU cores, 50gb for the disk size and 128mb for video memory.

After booting up I was greeted with a very dapper desktop. I enjoyed the colors and tones and simple look.

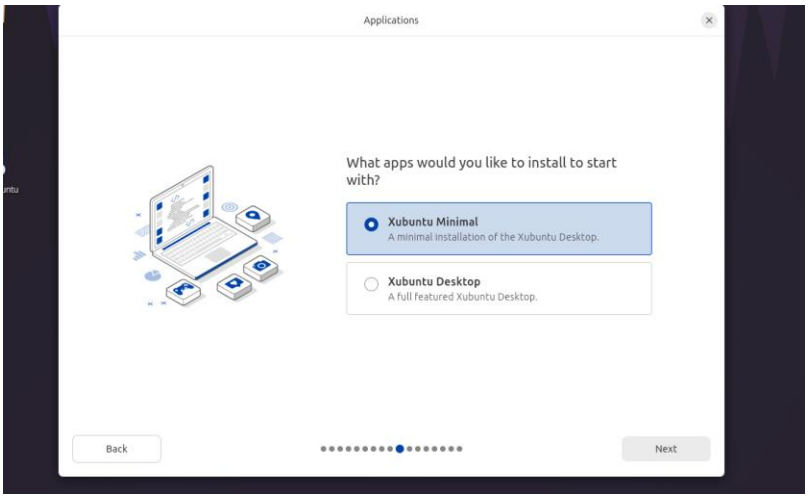


The menu and task bar are on top, and the file explorer looks clean

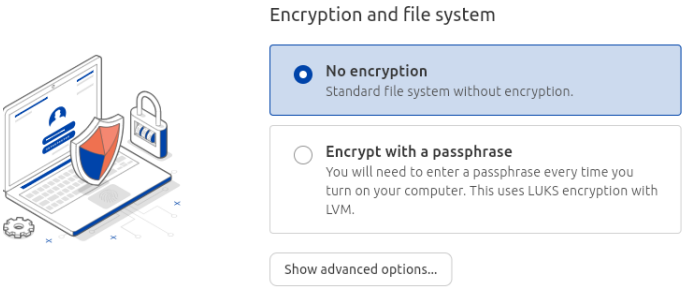


It had some of the standers in open source we have been seeing. Libre office for document editing, rhythm box for audio and parole media player for videos. After a quick poke around I went back to the desktop and clicked on the install to start the process.

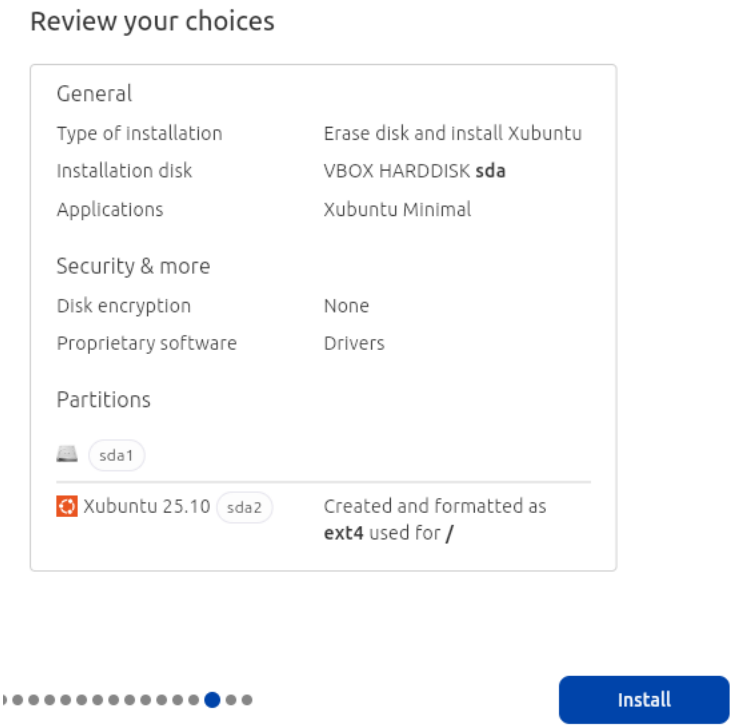
During installation I saw a lot of the same things from the other distros but quickly on I was prompted with a full or minimal installation... I like this because its advertised as being sleek and elegant. I felt a difference using fedora on the speed of things opening and navigating the os in general. But on this live install of Xubuntu things are FLYING. I'm assuming its the desktop environments?



Encryption was offered I said no thank you this time around. Its uses LUKS



Ext4 for the filesystem as per system default.



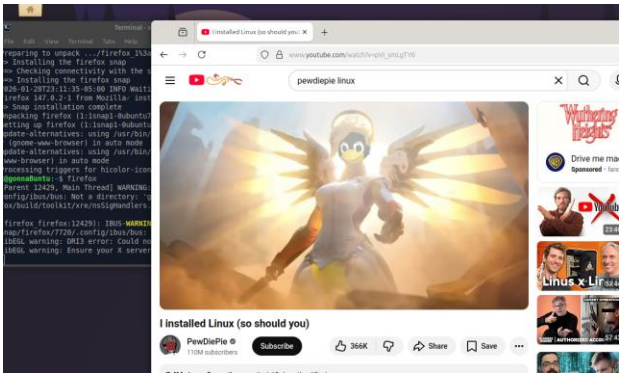
Reboot after installing. A quick poke around to find our beloved libre office...it wasn't there. I forgot I picked minimal. So I will have to install each of the items I was testing out on the other distros.

“sudo apt install firefox” for web browser.

“sudo apt install mousepad” for text editor

“sudo apt install vlc” for media

With these three I'm setup and can start to expand and build.



```
x@gonnaBuntu:~$ uname -a
Linux gonnaBuntu 6.17.0-8-generic #8-Ubuntu SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Fri Nov 14 21:44
:46 UTC 2025 x86_64 GNU/Linux
x@gonnaBuntu:~$
```

Xubuntu was quick and easy to use. I liked the option for minimal installation. I think half the fun of linux is using the terminal, and I didn't mind the few extra keystrokes to download my beloved Firefox. the XFCE desktop environment felt fast and the os was easy to navigate.

Conclusions and comparisons

I did my best to vary settings logically and explore each in a similar way. One thing i noted is that encryption is easy to do and as simple as putting in an extra password and could protect your data a lot better than just locking your laptop so for anyone who is worried about that kind of thing all of these distros offered it and it was easy to get to. Most of the difference I felt where in the desktop environments. Xubuntu and Fedora felt faster compared to the other two. At first I thought it was me but when researching it I found that was feeling was correct. Each distro shared some similarities but felt different in its own way. Mint felt simple and easy; fedora felt fast and looked and operated a little different than the others as far as desktop functions and menus/toolbars. OpenSUSE felt powerful. I liked that one a lot for its no training wheels feeling… all the settings and options the others had plus more was out in the open and there right from the beginning. Xubuntu had the feel/look of mint but ran a little faster and offered more customization for the system on install.

Alot of my reference was asking ChatGPT to clarify something that I couldn't find an answer to quickly in the documentation. Any sort of troubleshoot or quick clarification question i usually direct to a conversation with whatever the newest model is at the time. I will feed it some content before i start. My notes. The project guidelines and whatever links I can gather that are relevant in a quick search. The current model in use is ChatGPT 5.2

Quick guide to Virtual Box

https://www.nakivo.com/blog/use-virtualbox-quick-overview/

Xubuntu documentation

https://xubuntu.github.io/xubuntu-docs/user/C/index.html

Fedora documentation

https://docs.fedoraproject.org/en-US/workstation-docs/

Linux mint Faq page (had the best info)

https://linuxmint.com/faq.php

OpenSUSE documentation

https://doc.opensuse.org/documentation/tumbleweed/kde/

I'm not huge on reddit but I found myself here twice

https://www.reddit.com/r/linux4noobs/

All YouTube videos were listed above in text